chief minister and NC vice-president Omar Abdullah urge people to use their vote as a "public verdict" on the Narendra Modi-led Union government's unilateral decision.

"Kargil has spoken against the decision...when democracy was snatched from us and we were pushed into a bureaucratic quagmire," says NC district president Haji Hanifa Jan, a former chief executive councillor. "People in Ladakh are distraught. We hope the Government of India will think about Ladakh in the backdrop of the result." Jan himself lost the election by just 66 votes in a 'friendly contest' with the Congress in Baroo. (The two allies had fielded separate candidates in many seats where the chances of a BJP win were negligible.)

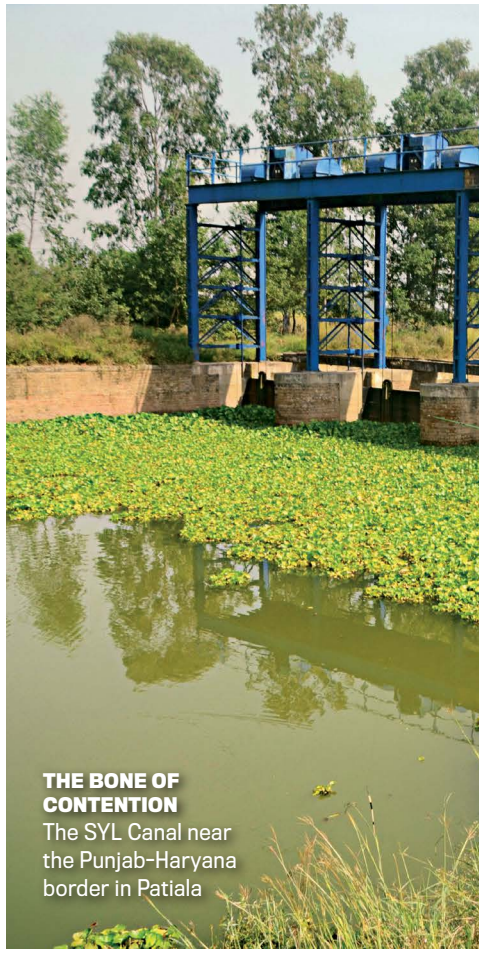
THE NC-CONGRESS COMBINE CALLS ITS MASSIVE WIN A VERDICT AGAINST THE ANNULMENT OF ARTICLE 370

Ladakh, which comprises an ideologically and politically divergent Buddhist-Muslim population, is administered by two autonomous bodies—the Leh council set up in 1995 and the Kargil council that followed much later, in 2002. Each is led by a chairperson and an executive council, elected every five years. The BJP won the election in the Buddhist-dominated Leh for a second consecutive term in October 2020. The Muslim-majority Kargil went to the polls on October 4, registering an impressive 77.6 per cent turnout.

As per the coalition pact, the winning allies will hold the top post in rotation for two and a half years each. But many former councillors fear that it won't be easy for the NC-Congress combine to run the council in the face of constant "interference" by the Ladakh administration. "Ever since Ladakh was carved out as a UT in 2019," says former Kargil council chairman Feroz Khan, "the autonomy of both councils has been curtailed." He cites the lack of fresh business rules to demarcate the role of the UT administration as a "deliberate" attempt to venture into the councils' domain. "Bureaucrats are deciding on projects and their expenditure without consulting the councils," he rues. Even the power to transfer government employees, which was once the domain of the councils, has been withdrawn. "The administrative and financial powers of councils should be strengthened," says Khan, "because now they are the only elected bodies in Ladakh."

The BJP, meanwhile, denies that the Kargil poll verdict is against the scrapping of Article 370. "The results show that we are strengthening our roots in Kargil," says BJP's J&K spokesperson Altaf Thakur, citing the increase in the party's seat tally from one to two. "Our candidates would not have lost by a narrow margin from three seats," he adds, "and would not have been runners-up in seven seats if people were unhappy with the August 2019 decision."

The Kargil poll has also put the spotlight on the long-delayed election in J&K, which is without a functioning assembly and is being ruled directly by the Centre since the fall of the People's Democratic Party (PDP)-BJP government in June 2018. New Delhi was readying to conduct panchayat and urban local body polls after their five-year term ends this year, but there are enough hints indicating a further delay. Union home minister Amit Shah is reported to have told the BJP's J&K unit on September 25 to gear up for the Lok Sabha election next year, suggesting the party is not keen on taking a chance with any adverse verdict by holding the local body polls before that. Kargil is unlikely to change that. ■



THE BONE OF CONTENTION
The SYL Canal near the Punjab-Haryana border in Patiala

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The emotive issue of the Sutlej-Yamuna Link (SYL) Canal has once again taken political centrestage in Punjab after the Supreme Court on October 4 pulled up the state government for dilly-dallying on its construction and directed the Union government to survey the portion of the land allocated to the project in the riparian state.

The Centre has been categorically told to keep in mind the apex court's 2002 decree, which mandated that Punjab should honour its commitments on water-sharing with Haryana. It was also directed to verify Punjab's assertion that it